Yet, while there are no ‘neutral’ or ‘objective’ stories, among people who share certain standards of truth and morality, some stories are decidedly superior, possessing more explanatory power than others. And perhaps the best tool human civilizations have evolved to identify such stories is modern scholarship, which attempts to expand knowledge about cultures and texts, subject to ongoing revision based on new evidence, fresh analysis and debate by a diverse community of scholars. This tool does not—at least not by design—put the cart of interpretation before the horse of facts. Rather, it is an enterprise in which historical knowledge evolves led by new facts and persuasive interpretations. It’s not perfect, but alternatives divorced from such an approach seem to me decidedly worse.

As historian Modris Eksteins writes in *Walking Since Daybreak*, ‘It is not possible to write history without preconception. It is possible, however, to write history with layers of suggestion, so that history evokes, history conjoins, it involves. History should provoke, not dictate meaning. It should be a vehicle rather than a terminus.’ The result, one hopes, is an account that both opens up and advances new understandings of the past.

I’ve read scores of historians in my adult life. I’ve liked some more than others. Who, in my view, makes a good historian? One with ample sensitivity, imagination, depth of perception, the right distance and the ability to synthesize vast bits of social knowledge. One who tries ‘to see the world as its members saw it, and understand, to the extent possible, what it was like to live in it’.[2] One who labours over linguistic clarity and analytical rigour and frets about the quality of her sources and being truthful to herself. One who possesses a judicious *sense of history*, the kind that comes from sustained reflection on human societies across time and place.

Furthermore, she knows that historical sources can lie, that things are often not what they seem. Indian court chroniclers often inflated the political, cultural, military and sexual exploits of their patrons. Classical Athenian art can lead us to overestimate the social status of women in that society, as Khajuraho’s erotic art can convey a misleading view of most women’s sexual freedom in the time of the Chandelas. Ancient and medieval travellers, who rarely spoke local languages, often recorded errors, hearsay and matters ‘lost in translation’ as truth. Consider: If a far